

The Surfing SWAMIS

Surfing is set to take off in a big way in India, thanks to pioneering efforts of a little-known ashram in Mangalore



Photographs: SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN

By Nirmala Ravindran

It is seven in the morning and the rising sun bathes the beach a golden yellow at Mulki, a tiny hamlet off the coast of Mangalore. It is a common sight for the villagers, who live by the river mouth, to spot a motley crew of six to eight people carrying colourful surf boards and heading to the beach. A small boat transports the team to a clean, uninhabited beach and for the next few hours, the group paddles with their surf boards, looking for the right wave to break. Good waves and suc-

“ India will attract a lot of surfing talent in the future. The sport will only grow as the young take to it. ”

◀ SWAMI NARASINGHA, FOUNDER, KMA

ASHRAM SURFERS ALONG WITH ISHITA (LEFT) AND PATHIYAN (EXTREME RIGHT) FROM MANIPAL AT MULKI

cessful attempts draw cheers from the rest of the team. What is not so common is the identity of the surfers: they are all inmates of the Kaliya Mardana Ashram (KMA) at Mulki, founded by Swami Narasingha, a 65-year-old swami of American origin. And their goal, apart from the spiritual ones, is to promote surfing in India.

India is perhaps the last frontier when it comes to surfing, with a nearly 7,000 km of unharnessed coastline. While surfing is a multi-billion-dollar industry abroad, it was virtually unheard of in India till five years ago. The last few years have, however, seen that change, thanks to the efforts of the ashram. “I knew that ashram members would really get into surfing because most of them were young